Note: style > **compressed essayistic clarity** / - **Peter Turchin** / - **Isaiah Berlin**

1. The Instability of Satisfaction**

> Human satisfaction has a strange property: it fades quickly.

> The hedonic treadmill is not just a psychological curiosity. Over centuries, entire civilisations developed cultural systems designed to manage it.

> Humans adapt quickly to improvements in their circumstances. A promotion, a successful project, a new home—each briefly changes how the world feels. Then the change fades, expectations reset, and attention shifts to the next goal.

> Long before psychology named this process, philosophers had already noticed it. Pleasure fades, success loses intensity, and desire quickly renews itself.

> Some traditions responded by reducing desire. Buddhist thinkers argued that suffering arises from craving; freedom lies in loosening attachment. Epicurus similarly concluded that tranquility comes not from acquiring more but from wanting less.

> Other traditions tried to reconcile ambition with stability. Aristotle believed fulfillment came from excellence rather than pleasure. The Bhagavad Gita encouraged action without attachment to results.
>
> These ideas differ in tone, but they respond to the same observation: happiness is unstable.

> Yet philosophy alone was never the full answer. Entire civilisations eventually confronted the same psychological problem, and their solutions were not merely individual practices but social systems. Religions, moral codes, and cultural ideals all helped people interpret success, failure, suffering, and ambition in ways that made life feel meaningful despite the fading of satisfaction.

2. From Philosophers to Civilisations: Why We Need a Bigger Map

Individual philosophers can offer powerful insights into the human condition. But they rarely stand alone. Behind every thinker lies a cultural world that shaped the questions they asked and the answers that felt plausible.

Aristotle did not emerge in a vacuum. His vision of human flourishing—cultivating excellence within a community of citizens—reflects the social world of the Greek city-state. Confucius's emphasis on harmony and ritual grew from centuries of political disorder in ancient China and the urgent need to restore stable social hierarchies. The Buddha's diagnosis of suffering was formed in a civilisation deeply preoccupied with cycles of birth, death, and rebirth.

Philosophers often appear as solitary figures, but in reality they are the most articulate voices of much larger cultural conversations.

Civilisations, over long stretches of history, develop coherent ways of interpreting the human predicament. They accumulate shared intuitions about suffering, success, duty, and meaning. These intuitions are reinforced through religious traditions, political structures, stories, and everyday social practices.

Seen from this angle, philosophy becomes less like a set of isolated theories and more like a **distillation of civilisational experience**.

This shift in perspective matters for our problem. The hedonic treadmill—the discovery that pleasure fades and satisfaction rarely lasts—is not something any single thinker discovered. It is something entire cultures noticed again and again.

And rather than agreeing on one universal solution, civilisations built **different ways of living with that reality**.

The Mediterranean world, shaped by vibrant public life and political competition, developed an ideal of human flourishing rooted in excellence and balance. A good life meant cultivating virtue, participating in civic life, and enjoying the pleasures of friendship and beauty while they lasted.

In India, where philosophical traditions often focused on impermanence and the cycles of existence, the dominant response was different. Instead of stabilising pleasure, many Indian traditions sought to loosen the individual's attachment to it entirely.

Northern Europe, forged in harsher climates and later shaken by the collapse of religious certainty, moved toward a different solution again: meaning as something created through strength, will, and individual responsibility.

Russia, shaped by immense suffering and spiritual intensity, developed a moral imagination in which suffering itself could become a path toward redemption and depth.

In East Asia, the answer lay less in individual psychology and more in the creation of harmonious social structures. A stable network of roles, rituals, and obligations provided continuity even when personal emotions fluctuated.

Jewish civilisation, forged in centuries of exile and survival, developed a different orientation still: meaning through responsibility, memory, and the continual effort to repair the world.

Islamic civilisation redirected the search for satisfaction upward, toward a transcendent order in which human desire finds its proper orientation through submission to the divine.

And in Polynesian cultures, shaped by life in close relationship with the ocean and the natural world, identity itself often softened into a broader sense of belonging within living ecosystems.

These responses differ dramatically in their details, yet they share a common origin. Each emerged from a culture that had, in its own way, confronted the same unsettling discovery: the pleasures of life are real, but they rarely remain satisfying for long.

The important point is not to rank these traditions or to claim that any single one offers the final answer. Each represents a **civilisational strategy**—a way of organising values, expectations, and social life so that human beings can live meaningfully despite the instability of happiness.

Looking at these traditions side by side reveals something that is difficult to see from within any one culture. What appears natural or obvious in one civilisation is often only one possible response among many.

The Mediterranean emphasis on balanced excellence, the Indian pursuit of detachment, the Northern European celebration of will, the Russian embrace of suffering, the Confucian focus on role and harmony—each represents a different way of standing within the same human condition.

If the hedonic treadmill is universal, then these civilisational responses form a kind of **map**. Not a set of instructions, but a landscape of possibilities that humanity has explored over centuries.

Understanding that map is the first step toward seeing the problem more clearly—and perhaps toward choosing more deliberately how we want to live within it.

3. Civilisational Profiles

If the hedonic treadmill is universal, the real diversity of human responses appears at the level of civilisation. Over centuries, cultures develop stable intuitions about what life is for, how suffering should be interpreted, and where meaning ultimately resides.

These intuitions are rarely stated as abstract theories. They are embedded in religious traditions, social norms, literature, and daily practices. Yet beneath the surface they reveal coherent strategies—ways of organising life so that human beings can live meaningfully despite the instability of pleasure.

Each of the following traditions can be understood as a **civilisational response** to the same underlying discovery: happiness fades, and life must therefore be built around something deeper.

3.1 Mediterranean / Aristotelian

Defining pressure:

The classical Mediterranean world was politically unstable yet socially vibrant. Greek city-states competed, alliances shifted, and political life could be turbulent. At the same time, the Mediterranean climate and culture fostered public life, conversation, art, and civic participation.

Within this environment, the question was not how to escape life's fluctuations but how to live well inside them.

Core mechanism:

The Mediterranean answer, articulated most clearly by Aristotle, was **human flourishing through excellence**. A good life was not defined by fleeting pleasure but by the cultivation of virtues: courage, moderation, wisdom, justice, and friendship.

Pleasure still mattered, but it was treated as a by-product of living well rather than the primary goal. The deeper aim was *eudaimonia*—a flourishing life in which one's capacities are developed and exercised within a community.

Positive strengths

This model produces a culture that values:

- mastery and skill
- balanced ambition
- appreciation of beauty and friendship
- civic engagement and dialogue

Rather than rejecting worldly life, it seeks to elevate it through cultivation and discipline. A flourishing life is active, social, and rich in human relationships.

Shadow

The Mediterranean model works best when society itself remains relatively stable. When political order collapses or tragedy overwhelms ordinary life, the emphasis on balance and moderation can feel fragile.

Cultures built around flourishing can struggle when history becomes catastrophic.

3.2 Indian (Buddha + Gita)

Defining pressure:

Indian philosophical traditions were deeply shaped by the recognition of impermanence and suffering. The cycles of life, death, and rebirth—central to many Indian worldviews—encouraged a profound reflection on the transient nature of worldly achievement.

Core mechanism:

The Indian response often takes the form of **detachment from craving**.

In Buddhism, suffering arises from the mind's endless grasping for pleasant experiences and resistance to unpleasant ones. Liberation comes from seeing through this process and gradually loosening the attachment that drives it.

The *Bhagavad Gita* offers a complementary insight: act fully in the world, but relinquish attachment to outcomes. Action remains necessary, but the psychological weight of success and failure can be released.

Positive strengths

This tradition offers extraordinary psychological clarity:

- freedom from compulsive desire
- inner serenity
- the ability to endure change without constant agitation

It provides tools for observing the mind itself, revealing how much suffering arises not from events but from our reactions to them.

Shadow

Detachment, if misunderstood, can drift into disengagement. The effort to transcend worldly attachment may weaken the impulse to transform the world itself.

In its extreme forms, the pursuit of liberation can tilt toward withdrawal from ordinary life.

3.3 Northern European / Nietzschean

Defining pressure:

Northern Europe developed under very different conditions. Harsh climates, sparse populations, and later the gradual erosion of traditional religious certainties produced cultures in which individuals often had to rely on their own strength and initiative.

By the nineteenth century, thinkers such as Friedrich Nietzsche were confronting a new reality: the old religious frameworks that once gave life meaning were losing their authority.

Core mechanism:

The response that emerged was **meaning through self-creation**.

Nietzsche argued that the decline of inherited belief systems did not have to lead to despair. Instead, individuals could create meaning through strength, creativity, and the courageous

affirmation of life—even its painful aspects.

Rather than escaping suffering, one learns to incorporate it into the process of growth.

Positive strengths

This approach cultivates:

- resilience and courage
- radical individuality
- creative ambition
- the willingness to confront difficult truths

It encourages people to take responsibility for the shape of their lives instead of relying on inherited structures.

Shadow

The burden of meaning shifts heavily onto the individual. Without shared frameworks, people can feel isolated, forced to construct purpose entirely on their own.

In its darker forms, this tradition risks sliding into nihilism or relentless competition.

3.4 Russian / Dostoevskian

Defining pressure:

Russian history has been marked by profound hardship: vast geography, political repression, and repeated social upheaval. At the same time, Russian culture developed a powerful spiritual tradition deeply influenced by Orthodox Christianity.

These conditions produced a distinctive moral imagination.

Core mechanism:

Russian thought often treats **suffering itself as a path toward depth and redemption**.

In the novels of Fyodor Dostoevsky, characters wrestle with guilt, faith, despair, and moral awakening. Pain is not simply something to be avoided; it can become a source of spiritual insight and transformation.

Suffering strips away illusions and forces individuals to confront the deepest questions of existence.

Positive strengths

This tradition cultivates:

- emotional and spiritual depth
- empathy for the suffering of others
- moral seriousness about human life

It produces a powerful sensitivity to the tragedies and contradictions of existence.

Shadow

The danger lies in romanticising suffering itself. If hardship becomes morally exalted, prosperity and stability may appear shallow or even suspect.

In extreme forms, this outlook can encourage a fatalistic acceptance of pain.

3.5 East Asian / Confucian

Defining pressure:

East Asian civilisations, particularly China, faced the challenge of maintaining stability across vast and complex societies. Periods of political fragmentation revealed how destructive disorder could be.

The central question became: how can society remain harmonious despite the variability of human emotions and ambitions?

Core mechanism:

The Confucian answer was **role, ritual, and harmony**.

Meaning arises not primarily from internal psychological states but from fulfilling one's roles responsibly—child, parent, ruler, citizen. Rituals and social norms guide behavior, creating continuity and mutual respect across generations.

Instead of focusing on individual happiness, the tradition emphasizes the stability of the social fabric.

Positive strengths

This model fosters:

- social cohesion
- responsibility and respect
- dignity in everyday duties
- continuity between generations

By embedding individuals in a stable network of relationships, it provides meaning even when personal emotions fluctuate.

Shadow

The emphasis on harmony can suppress individuality. Conformity may become more valued than originality, and social pressure can discourage dissent.

Creativity and personal freedom sometimes struggle within strongly hierarchical systems.

3.6 Jewish

Defining pressure:

Jewish civilisation developed under the extraordinary conditions of repeated exile, persecution, and cultural survival across centuries.

Maintaining identity in the absence of political sovereignty required remarkable resilience.

Core mechanism:

The Jewish response centers on **obligation and repair**.

Life gains meaning through adherence to ethical commandments, communal responsibility, and the ongoing effort to repair the world—*tikkun olam*. History may be unstable, but moral responsibility persists.

Memory, study, and law become anchors of continuity.

Positive strengths

This tradition cultivates:

- intellectual intensity
- moral responsibility
- resilience under adversity
- deep communal bonds

Even under conditions of displacement, identity remains strong.

Shadow

The constant emphasis on responsibility and survival can create a sense of perpetual urgency. Rest and simple contentment may feel secondary to the work of maintaining and improving the world.

3.7 Islamic

Defining pressure:

Islamic civilisation developed around a powerful vision of divine unity and moral order. In a world marked by uncertainty and conflict, the tradition emphasised the sovereignty of God and the coherence of creation under divine guidance.

Core mechanism:

The Islamic response is to **orient human desire toward the infinite**.

Submission to God (*Islam* literally means “submission”) provides a framework in which the instability of worldly pleasures becomes less troubling. Life gains meaning through alignment with a transcendent moral order.

Daily practices—prayer, charity, fasting—continually reinforce this orientation.

Positive strengths

This worldview encourages:

- unity between spiritual and everyday life
- humility before the limits of human control
- strong moral and communal identity

By anchoring meaning in the divine, it provides stability beyond the fluctuations of worldly success.

Shadow

The emphasis on divine sovereignty can, in some contexts, tilt toward fatalism. When human agency is downplayed, social change and innovation may encounter resistance.

3.8 Polynesian

Defining pressure:

Polynesian cultures developed in environments defined by the ocean and close ecological interdependence. Life depended on maintaining balance with the natural world and the community.

Core mechanism:

In many Polynesian traditions, identity itself becomes more **diffuse and relational**.

The self is not understood as an isolated individual pursuing personal success but as part of a living network—family, ancestors, land, and sea. Meaning arises through participation in this larger web of life.

Positive strengths

This orientation fosters:

- deep connection with nature
- strong communal bonds
- a sense of belonging that extends beyond the individual

It often produces cultures in which everyday life is integrated with ecological awareness.

Shadow

Such systems can be vulnerable when exposed to rapid external disruption. Colonialism, globalization, and economic change can destabilize societies built around delicate ecological and social balances.

Scaling this model to large, modern societies can also prove difficult.

Across these traditions, the diversity of human responses becomes clear. Each civilisation discovered that happiness alone could not anchor a life. Each therefore built a different structure around which meaning could revolve.

Some emphasise mastery.

Others detachment.

Others will, suffering, harmony, obligation, transcendence, or belonging.

Together they form a map—not of perfect solutions, but of the many ways human cultures have learned to live with the same fundamental truth: pleasure fades, but life does not have to lose its meaning when it does.

4. Civilisations in Contact: Tensions and Mirrors

When civilisations meet, they do not merely exchange goods or technologies. They bring with them deeply embedded assumptions about what life is for, what suffering means, and how meaning should be pursued.

Because each civilisation developed its worldview as a response to the same underlying human problem—the instability of happiness—these responses often clash when placed side by side. What appears wise in one tradition may appear misguided or even immoral in another.

These clashes are not accidents. They reveal the **trade-offs embedded in each strategy for living with the hedonic treadmill**.

A few comparisons illuminate this dynamic particularly clearly.

Northern Europe vs Mediterranean

Endurance vs flourishing

The Mediterranean tradition, shaped by Aristotle and the culture of the classical city-state, celebrates a balanced life of cultivated excellence. Flourishing means developing one's abilities within a rich social world—friendship, civic participation, conversation, and beauty.

Northern European culture, especially in its modern philosophical expression, tends to place greater emphasis on endurance and self-creation. Where the Mediterranean tradition seeks harmony and balance, the Northern European temperament is often comfortable with struggle and tension.

This difference reflects distinct historical experiences. Mediterranean cultures historically flourished in environments conducive to public life and artistic expression. Northern Europe, facing harsher climates and later the erosion of religious certainty, cultivated traditions of individual resilience.

Each approach has strengths.

The Mediterranean model excels at **making life enjoyable and humane**. It reminds us that achievement alone is not enough; friendship, beauty, and community are essential.

The Northern European model excels at **facing adversity directly**. It prepares individuals to create meaning even when external structures collapse.

Yet the traditions often misunderstand one another. To Mediterranean eyes, the Northern emphasis on relentless striving can appear unnecessarily severe. To Northern European sensibilities, the Mediterranean focus on balance may seem complacent or insufficiently serious.

In reality, both traditions illuminate different aspects of the same human problem.

Jewish vs Mediterranean

Responsibility vs enjoyment

Mediterranean cultures often emphasize the art of living well: cultivating beauty, conversation, pleasure, and friendship.

Jewish civilisation, forged through centuries of exile and survival, developed a different orientation. The focus is less on enjoying the world as it exists and more on **repairing what is broken within it**.

Where Mediterranean thought might ask, *How can we flourish?*

Jewish thought often asks, *What responsibilities do we carry?*

This difference produces striking cultural contrasts.

The Mediterranean model nurtures a sense that life, despite its difficulties, should be savored. Jewish tradition frequently treats life as a moral project requiring continuous effort, memory, and obligation.

Both orientations offer wisdom.

The Mediterranean tradition protects the capacity for joy and appreciation. Jewish civilisation cultivates extraordinary resilience and moral seriousness.

But each also contains a shadow.

The Mediterranean approach can sometimes underestimate the depth of historical suffering. Jewish moral urgency can make rest and simple contentment feel secondary.

Jewish vs Northern European

Collective responsibility vs individual creation

The Northern European response to fading happiness often emphasizes individual strength. Meaning must be created by the person who refuses to surrender to nihilism.

Jewish civilisation approaches the problem differently. Instead of placing the burden entirely on the individual, it embeds meaning within a dense web of law, tradition, and communal obligation.

The individual does not need to invent meaning from nothing; meaning is already structured through collective memory and shared responsibility.

This difference reflects two distinct strategies for surviving uncertainty.

Northern European traditions encourage individuals to **stand alone if necessary**. Jewish civilisation encourages individuals to **stand together through shared commitments**.

The first produces remarkable independence and creativity. The second produces continuity and resilience across generations.

Each strategy, however, carries risks.

Excessive individualism can leave people isolated in their search for meaning. Strong communal frameworks can feel constraining to those who seek radical personal autonomy.

Jewish vs Indian

Repair the world vs detach from it

Perhaps the most striking contrast appears between Jewish and Indian civilisational responses.

Indian traditions often approach suffering by loosening attachment to worldly outcomes. The cycle of desire and frustration can be transcended by understanding its psychological roots.

Jewish civilisation takes almost the opposite stance. Rather than stepping back from the world, it encourages deeper engagement with it. The imperfections of reality are not illusions to transcend but problems that demand ethical action.

In one framework, liberation lies in **detachment from the cycle of craving**.

In the other, meaning lies in **participating in the moral repair of the world**.

Both responses address the same human predicament but from radically different directions.

The Indian tradition offers profound psychological insight and inner freedom. Jewish tradition offers a powerful ethic of responsibility and historical continuity.

Placed side by side, they reveal that there is no single correct way to respond to the fading of happiness. Some cultures seek freedom from the cycle of desire; others seek meaning through action within it.

These comparisons illustrate an important principle.

Civilisations do not merely offer solutions; they embody **choices about what kind of life is worth living**.

Some prioritize serenity.

Others responsibility.

Others resilience, harmony, transcendence, or belonging.

Each strategy solves part of the problem and leaves another part exposed.

Seeing these tensions clearly is not a reason to reject any tradition. On the contrary, it is precisely what allows us to appreciate the depth of human experimentation in the search for meaning.

The hedonic treadmill may be universal. But the ways human beings have learned to stand upon it are astonishingly diverse.

4.5 What Each Civilisation Optimises For

Looking across these traditions side by side reveals something important. Civilisations are not simply offering different techniques for happiness. They are **optimising for different problems**.

Each tradition begins with a particular fear about the human condition. From that fear emerges a strategy for organising life so that meaning remains possible even when pleasure fades.

Seen this way, the diversity of civilisational wisdom becomes easier to understand. What appears like disagreement is often simply a difference in **what each culture considers the greatest danger**.

Some fear chaos.

Others fear endless craving.

Others fear meaninglessness, exile, or spiritual emptiness.

Their philosophies are attempts to build stable lives around those fears.

Tradition	Core Fear	Core Strategy
Mediterranean	chaos destroying beauty	cultivate excellence and balanced flourishing
Indian	endless craving and attachment	detach from desire
Northern European	meaninglessness after the collapse of tradition	create meaning through will and action
Russian	a world without spiritual depth	redeem suffering through moral struggle
East Asian	social disorder and fragmentation	harmonise roles and relationships
Jewish	exile, loss, and historical rupture	sustain identity through responsibility and repair
Islamic	spiritual emptiness and moral disorientation	orient desire toward God
Polynesian	separation from nature and community	dissolve the individual into the living world

This framework highlights an important pattern.

Mediterranean culture protects **human flourishing**.

Indian traditions protect **inner freedom**.

Northern European thought protects **individual strength**.

Russian culture protects **moral depth**.

Confucian civilisation protects **social harmony**.

Jewish civilisation protects **ethical responsibility and continuity**.

Islamic civilisation protects **spiritual orientation**.

Polynesian cultures protect **ecological belonging**.

Each response addresses a real vulnerability in human life. Yet no single civilisation solves the entire problem.

The Mediterranean love of flourishing can appear fragile in times of catastrophe. Indian detachment can drift toward disengagement from worldly responsibility. Northern European self-creation can become lonely and exhausting. Russian moral seriousness can romanticise suffering. Confucian harmony may suppress individuality. Jewish urgency can make rest difficult. Islamic transcendence may struggle with secular modernity. Polynesian integration with nature can be vulnerable to external disruption.

In other words, every solution that stabilises life against the fading of happiness does so by **prioritising one dimension of human existence over others**.

Civilisations are therefore not merely collections of beliefs. They are long-term experiments in answering a single question:

If happiness cannot anchor a life, what should?

The answers humanity has produced are remarkably diverse. And it is only by placing them next to each other that we begin to see the full map of possibilities.

5 The Strengths and Shadows of Civilisational Wisdom

The civilisations we have explored did not merely produce ideas. They produced **ways of orienting a life**.

Each tradition discovered a mechanism that stabilises meaning when happiness fades. But each mechanism works by prioritising one dimension of life over others. What begins as wisdom can, if taken too far, become distortion.

Understanding these traditions therefore means understanding **both their power and their shadow**.

They are not universal formulas. They are lenses—each clarifying one part of the human condition while leaving another in partial darkness.

Aristotelian Mastery

Meaning through excellence

The Mediterranean tradition, articulated most clearly by Aristotle, proposes that the deepest satisfaction comes not from fleeting pleasure but from **developing and exercising human capacities well**.

A flourishing life involves cultivating virtue, pursuing mastery in one's craft, nurturing friendships, and participating in a community that values excellence.

Positive power

This approach gives structure to ambition. It encourages disciplined growth rather than endless consumption. When life is organised around mastery, satisfaction accumulates through the steady refinement of skill and character.

For modern life, this model is particularly powerful in domains that reward long-term development—craft, leadership, teaching, art, and intellectual work.

It also preserves something important that many philosophical traditions risk losing: **the legitimacy of enjoyment**. Beauty, friendship, and celebration are not distractions from life but integral parts of flourishing.

Shadow

The Aristotelian vision assumes that the world allows space for flourishing. When historical upheaval or personal tragedy overwhelms ordinary life, the model can appear fragile.

Balance and cultivation require conditions that are not always guaranteed.

Karma Yoga

Action without attachment

The *Bhagavad Gita* presents one of the most psychologically subtle solutions to the hedonic treadmill.

Human beings are instructed to act fully in the world—to pursue their duties and responsibilities—but to relinquish attachment to the results.

Effort remains intense. Outcomes are released.

Positive power

This approach solves a central tension of modern life: how to remain ambitious without becoming emotionally enslaved to success or failure.

By shifting attention from outcomes to the integrity of action itself, the Gita allows individuals to maintain discipline and engagement while reducing the anxiety generated by constant

evaluation.

Many high performers unknowingly rediscover this principle: focusing on the quality of the work rather than obsessing over the reward.

Shadow

Detachment from outcomes can drift toward indifference if misunderstood. When taken too far, the idea may weaken the drive to improve systems, challenge injustice, or pursue excellence.

The subtlety of the teaching is easily lost.

Nietzschean Affirmation

Meaning through self-creation

Nietzsche confronted a world in which traditional sources of meaning—especially religious ones—were losing their authority.

His answer was not resignation but defiance: individuals must learn to **create meaning through the courageous affirmation of life**, including its hardships.

Rather than escaping suffering, one learns to incorporate it into the process of becoming stronger and more creative.

Positive power

This outlook produces extraordinary resilience. It encourages individuals to confront reality honestly and to build meaning through achievement, creativity, and personal transformation.

It is especially powerful during periods of expansion—moments when ambition is high and individuals are willing to accept difficulty as the price of growth.

Shadow

The cost of this freedom is isolation. When meaning becomes a personal project, individuals may feel permanently responsible for constructing their own purpose.

Without shared frameworks, the pursuit of self-creation can become exhausting or competitive to a destructive degree.

Russian Depth Through Suffering

Meaning through moral struggle

Russian cultural traditions often approach suffering not merely as something to be endured but as something capable of revealing deeper truths about the human soul.

In the works of Dostoevsky, characters confront despair, guilt, and redemption with an emotional intensity rarely matched in other literary traditions.

Suffering becomes a path toward spiritual depth.

Positive power

This outlook fosters empathy and moral seriousness. It resists the superficial optimism that sometimes characterises modern life and insists that the darker aspects of human experience deserve attention.

It reminds us that depth often emerges through struggle.

Shadow

The danger lies in **romanticising suffering itself**. When hardship becomes morally elevated, prosperity and stability may appear shallow or suspect.

The tradition's strength—its seriousness—can also become its burden.

Confucian Role and Ritual

Meaning through responsibility

Confucian civilisation approaches the problem of fading happiness by embedding individuals within a network of relationships and responsibilities.

Instead of asking how each person can maximize personal satisfaction, the tradition asks how individuals can fulfill their roles with dignity and care.

Order, respect, and ritual stabilise social life.

Positive power

This framework provides continuity and clarity. When individuals know what is expected of them—as parents, children, teachers, or citizens—daily life gains structure and meaning.

It reduces the psychological burden of constant self-definition that characterises many modern societies.

Shadow

The same structures that create stability can also restrict freedom. Strong role expectations may suppress individuality or discourage dissent.

The challenge lies in maintaining harmony without suffocating creativity.

Jewish Moral Urgency

Meaning through responsibility and repair

Jewish civilisation responds to instability through an ethic of responsibility.

History may bring exile, loss, or injustice, but moral obligation persists. Through law, study, and communal memory, individuals participate in the ongoing project of repairing the world.

Positive power

This approach generates remarkable resilience and intellectual vitality. It encourages engagement with history, ethical reflection, and a sense that human action matters.

Meaning arises not from escaping the world's imperfections but from working to improve them.

Shadow

A life structured around responsibility can make rest difficult. The sense that the world requires continual repair may create a background of permanent urgency.

Joy can sometimes appear secondary to duty.

Buddhist Non-Attachment

Freedom through understanding desire

Returning to the original cluster of "want less" traditions, Buddhism offers perhaps the most refined psychological response to the hedonic treadmill.

By observing how craving arises in the mind and learning to loosen its grip, individuals can experience a profound reduction in suffering.

The treadmill loses much of its power when the mind stops running after every new desire.

Positive power

Few traditions offer deeper insight into the mechanics of human dissatisfaction. Meditation practices reveal how quickly the mind generates craving and how unnecessary much of that suffering actually is.

The result can be remarkable inner calm and clarity.

Shadow

The same detachment that produces serenity can also distance individuals from worldly engagement. If misunderstood, non-attachment may weaken ambition, creativity, or the impulse to transform difficult circumstances.

Taken together, these traditions reveal a striking pattern.

Every civilisation discovered that happiness alone is too unstable to anchor a life. Each therefore constructed a different foundation:

- mastery
- disciplined action
- self-creation
- moral struggle
- social responsibility
- ethical obligation
- psychological liberation

Each foundation stabilises meaning in a different way. Each also introduces its own risks.

The deeper lesson is not that one tradition must replace the others. It is that human cultures have spent centuries exploring the same problem from different angles.

The hedonic treadmill remains. But the range of human responses to it is far richer than a single philosophy could ever capture.

6. Conclusion: Dancing With the Wheel

The hedonic treadmill can feel like a discouraging discovery.

If satisfaction fades, if achievements quickly become normal, if pleasure never stabilises for long, then the pursuit of happiness begins to look strangely fragile. Many people encounter this realization gradually, often after years of striving. What once appeared to be the final milestone reveals itself as only another step.

But civilisations have lived with this knowledge for a very long time.

Long before psychologists named the phenomenon, cultures across the world noticed the same pattern. Pleasure fades. Success loses its intensity. Desire quietly resets and begins moving again.

Rather than treating this as a flaw in life, they built ways of living around it.

Some traditions concluded that the solution was to loosen the grip of desire itself. Others decided that meaning must be created through excellence, courage, responsibility, or

spiritual orientation. Some anchored life in social harmony, others in moral struggle, and still others in a deep sense of belonging within nature.

What they all shared was a refusal to treat happiness as the central foundation of a life.

The hedonic treadmill does not disappear. But it stops being the main reference point.

Instead, life becomes organised around something more durable: mastery, duty, transcendence, community, depth, or inner freedom.

Seen from this perspective, the diversity of civilisational wisdom begins to look less like disagreement and more like **a map of human experimentation**. Different cultures explored different ways of stabilising meaning in a world where pleasure inevitably fades.

No single tradition solves the problem completely. Each illuminates part of the landscape while leaving other areas less developed. Yet taken together they reveal something encouraging.

Human beings have never relied solely on happiness to justify their lives.

They have learned to build structures of meaning that remain standing even when the emotional weather changes.

The image of the treadmill therefore deserves a small correction.

We do not escape the wheel. Human desire continues to move, and new goals will always appear on the horizon. But once we understand the pattern, the relationship to it can change.

The person who studies the map of civilisational wisdom does not chase the next moment of satisfaction with the same desperation. Instead, he begins to shape his life around deeper principles—principles that remain meaningful even as moods and pleasures fluctuate.

In that sense, the goal is not to jump off the treadmill.

It is to learn **how to stand on it without letting it decide what life is for**.

And when that shift occurs, the wheel that once seemed exhausting becomes something else entirely: a movement within a larger life whose direction is no longer determined by the next fleeting reward.

Appendix A — Civilisational Response Matrix

The following matrix summarises the core patterns explored throughout the essay.

Each civilisation can be understood as a long-term cultural response to the same underlying discovery: **happiness fades and therefore cannot serve as the primary anchor of a life.**

The matrix highlights four elements:

- the **historical pressure or "wound"** that shaped the civilisation's worldview
- the **core mechanism** it developed in response
- the **positive strength** this mechanism produces
- the **shadow or distortion** that can appear when the mechanism is taken too far

Civilisation	Defining Pressure / Historical Wound	Core Mechanism	Positive Strength	Shadow
Mediterranean / Aristotelian	Political instability but rich civic culture	Flourishing through excellence, virtue, and community	Cultivation of mastery, beauty, friendship, and civic life	Fragile when stability collapses; assumes conditions that allow flourishing
Indian (Buddhist + Gita traditions)	Awareness of impermanence and cycles of suffering	Detachment from craving; action without attachment to results	Inner freedom, serenity, psychological clarity	Risk of withdrawal from worldly engagement
Northern European / Nietzschean	Harsh environments and erosion of inherited religious meaning	Creation of meaning through strength, will, and self-overcoming	Resilience, individuality, creative ambition	Isolation, existential pressure on the individual
Russian / Dostoevskian	Historical suffering, political upheaval, spiritual intensity	Suffering as a path toward moral and spiritual depth	Emotional depth, empathy, moral seriousness	Romanticising suffering; suspicion toward prosperity
East Asian / Confucian	Maintaining order in large, complex societies	Harmony through roles, ritual, and social responsibility	Social stability, dignity in duty, continuity across generations	Conformity; suppression of individuality
Jewish	Repeated exile, persecution, and cultural survival	Meaning through responsibility, law, and repairing the world	Intellectual vitality, resilience, ethical seriousness	Permanent urgency; difficulty resting in contentment
Islamic	Desire for moral and spiritual	Orientation of life toward	Unity of spiritual and	Risk of fatalism;

Civilisation	Defining Pressure / Historical Wound	Core Mechanism	Positive Strength	Shadow
	order under divine sovereignty	God and transcendent purpose	everyday life; strong communal identity	tension with secular modernity
Polynesian	Ecological interdependence in oceanic environments	Identity embedded in community and nature	Deep connection with nature and collective belonging	Vulnerable to external disruption; difficult to scale to modern states

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Reading the Matrix

This table does not claim that any civilisation is reducible to a single idea. Each contains internal diversity and centuries of evolution. The goal of the matrix is simply to highlight **the dominant pattern** that tends to appear when the tradition reflects on the instability of happiness.

Several patterns become visible when the traditions are viewed side by side.

Some responses emphasize **inner transformation** (Indian, Buddhist traditions).

Others emphasize **action in the world** (Mediterranean, Jewish).

Others emphasise **strength of the individual** (Northern European).

Others stabilise meaning through **social order** (Confucian).

Others through **spiritual transcendence** (Islamic).

Others through **moral depth in suffering** (Russian).

And some through **ecological belonging** (Polynesian).

Each strategy protects something valuable in human life. But each also leaves another dimension exposed.

The purpose of the matrix is therefore not to identify a “correct” civilisation but to reveal the remarkable range of human solutions to the same existential problem.

When happiness proves unstable, cultures do not give up on meaning.

They simply build it on different foundations.

Appendix B — Civilisational Pairwise Comparisons (Integrated Matrix)

The civilisational profiles in the main essay describe distinct strategies for living with the instability of happiness. When placed side by side, these strategies reveal patterns of **tension, complementarity, and philosophical contrast**.

The purpose of this appendix is not to judge which tradition is correct. Instead, it highlights how different civilisations respond to the same human problem from different angles. When their assumptions collide, the contrast often illuminates strengths and blind spots on both sides.

The comparisons below focus on the most instructive interactions among the traditions discussed in the essay.

Mediterranean / Aristotelian vs Other Traditions

Mediterranean vs Northern European

Flourishing vs endurance

The Mediterranean worldview centers on the cultivation of a balanced and flourishing life—mastery, friendship, beauty, and civic participation.

Northern European traditions often emphasize endurance and self-creation in a harsher world. Meaning must be forged through strength rather than discovered through balance.

The contrast reveals two interpretations of the good life:

one oriented toward **harmonious flourishing**, the other toward **resilient self-overcoming**.

Mediterranean vs Russian

Joy of life vs redemptive suffering

Mediterranean culture tends to treat life as something to be savored and cultivated.

Russian cultural traditions often emphasize suffering as a path toward moral and spiritual depth.

To Mediterranean sensibilities, the Russian fascination with suffering can appear heavy or tragic.

To Russian sensibilities, Mediterranean optimism can appear shallow or naïve.

The tension reflects different historical experiences with stability and catastrophe.

Mediterranean vs Jewish

Celebration vs responsibility

Mediterranean traditions emphasize the art of living well—friendship, conversation, pleasure, and beauty.

Jewish civilisation places stronger emphasis on ethical responsibility, historical memory, and the repair of the world.

Where the Mediterranean asks *How can we flourish?*

Jewish thought often asks *What obligations do we carry?*

The contrast illustrates the balance between **enjoying life** and **improving it**.

Mediterranean vs Indian

Cultivating life vs transcending desire

Mediterranean thought generally embraces worldly life and seeks to refine it through excellence.

Indian traditions often see worldly desire itself as the root of suffering and aim to transcend attachment to it.

The Mediterranean model deepens engagement with the world;

the Indian model loosens its psychological grip.

Mediterranean vs East Asian (Confucian)

Individual flourishing vs social harmony

Mediterranean traditions emphasize the flourishing of individuals within a community.

Confucian civilisation emphasizes the maintenance of harmonious roles within a structured social order.

Both value community, but the Mediterranean approach highlights **personal excellence**, while the Confucian model prioritizes **social stability**.

Mediterranean vs Islamic

Human flourishing vs divine orientation

Mediterranean philosophy often locates meaning within human capacities—reason, virtue, and civic life.

Islamic civilisation orients meaning toward God and divine order.

The contrast reflects different centers of gravity:

one grounded in **human flourishing**, the other in **spiritual submission**.

Mediterranean vs Polynesian

Cultivated civilisation vs ecological belonging

Mediterranean culture historically emphasizes cultivated civilisation—cities, institutions, and artistic development.

Polynesian traditions emphasize belonging within a living ecological network of land, sea, ancestors, and community.

The contrast reflects two different relationships with nature: shaping it versus living within it.

Northern European / Nietzschean vs Other Traditions

Northern European vs Russian

Self-created meaning vs spiritual suffering

Northern European philosophy, particularly in Nietzsche's work, treats meaning as something individuals must create through strength and self-overcoming.

Russian thought often views suffering as a gateway to spiritual depth rather than something to overcome through will.

Where Nietzsche proclaims **affirmation of life**, Russian literature often seeks **redemption through moral struggle**.

Northern European vs Jewish

Individual will vs collective responsibility

Northern European traditions emphasize the autonomy of the individual who creates meaning independently.

Jewish civilisation anchors meaning in shared law, communal responsibility, and historical continuity.

The contrast highlights two survival strategies:

standing alone versus standing together.

Northern European vs Indian

Affirmation vs detachment

Nietzschean thought affirms life—including its suffering—and encourages engagement with the world.

Indian traditions often pursue liberation through detachment from desire and the cycles of craving.

One celebrates the will to live intensely;

the other seeks freedom from the compulsions of desire.

Northern European vs Confucian

Radical individuality vs social harmony

Northern European philosophy often celebrates the individual who breaks with convention.

Confucian civilisation emphasizes the importance of fulfilling established social roles.

Where Nietzsche praises the individual who transcends norms, Confucian thought values the person who stabilizes society.

Northern European vs Islamic

Self-created meaning vs divine submission

Nietzschean philosophy asserts that meaning must be created by humans in a world where traditional religious certainties have weakened.

Islamic civilisation grounds meaning in submission to God.

The contrast illustrates two opposite responses to the question of authority:

human self-creation versus divine command.

Northern European vs Polynesian

Individual identity vs relational identity

Northern European traditions tend to treat identity as fundamentally individual.

Polynesian traditions often understand identity as relational—embedded within family, community, and the natural environment.

The contrast reflects two distinct understandings of the self.

Russian / Dostoevskian vs Other Traditions

Russian vs Jewish

Redemptive suffering vs ethical repair

Russian traditions often interpret suffering as spiritually meaningful.

Jewish civilisation focuses more strongly on confronting injustice and repairing the world.

One tradition deepens meaning through suffering itself;

the other seeks to transform the conditions that produce suffering.

Russian vs Indian

Suffering as meaning vs suffering as illusion

Indian traditions frequently interpret suffering as arising from attachment and ignorance.

Russian thought often treats suffering as morally and spiritually meaningful.

The Indian path seeks liberation from suffering;

the Russian path seeks truth through it.

Russian vs Confucian

Existential depth vs social order

Russian literature often explores extreme psychological and spiritual struggles.

Confucian civilisation prioritizes stability and harmony within society.

The Russian tradition dives into existential conflict;

the Confucian tradition attempts to prevent it.

Russian vs Islamic

Tragic faith vs ordered faith

Both traditions contain strong spiritual elements, but they emphasize different aspects of religious experience.

Russian spirituality often dwells in tension, doubt, and moral struggle.

Islamic civilisation emphasizes submission to divine order and the coherence of God’s will.

Russian vs Polynesian

Spiritual tragedy vs natural belonging

Russian thought often explores the tragic dimensions of existence.

Polynesian traditions emphasize harmony with nature and community.

The contrast illustrates two ways of situating the human being in the cosmos:

through existential struggle or ecological belonging.

Jewish vs Other Traditions

Jewish vs Indian

Repair the world vs transcend the world

Jewish civilisation encourages ethical engagement with history and society.

Indian traditions often pursue liberation from worldly cycles of desire.

One path emphasizes action within history;

the other seeks freedom beyond it.

Jewish vs Confucian

Covenantal responsibility vs social hierarchy

Jewish tradition organizes meaning around covenant, law, and ethical obligation.

Confucian civilisation structures meaning around hierarchical roles and social harmony.

Both emphasize duty but anchor it in different frameworks.

Jewish vs Islamic

Lawful covenant vs submission

Both traditions are strongly shaped by religious law.

Jewish civilisation emphasizes covenantal responsibility between God and a particular community.

Islamic civilisation emphasizes universal submission to God’s will.

Jewish vs Polynesian

Historical identity vs ecological belonging

Jewish identity is deeply tied to historical memory and textual tradition.

Polynesian identity is often rooted in land, ancestry, and ecological relationships.

Both offer strong communal identity but derive it from different sources.

East Asian / Confucian vs Other Traditions

Confucian vs Indian

Social order vs spiritual liberation

Confucian civilisation emphasizes harmony in social relationships.

Indian traditions often prioritize liberation from worldly cycles.

The former organizes life within society;

the latter often seeks freedom from its constraints.

Confucian vs Islamic

Ritual harmony vs divine law

Confucian traditions organize society through ritual and hierarchical roles.

Islamic civilisation structures life around divine law and submission to God.

Both produce ordered societies but draw authority from different sources.

Confucian vs Polynesian

Structured hierarchy vs organic community

Confucian society emphasizes carefully defined hierarchies.

Polynesian communities often emphasize relational belonging within ecological networks.

Both value community but structure it differently.

Islamic vs Polynesian

Transcendent order vs ecological belonging

Islamic civilisation grounds meaning in a transcendent divine order.

Polynesian traditions often ground meaning in the living world itself.

One points upward toward the divine;

the other outward toward the interconnectedness of nature.

Appendix D — Key Thinkers and Texts

The civilisational patterns described in this essay did not arise from a single author or moment in history. They are the result of long cultural developments expressed through religion, philosophy, literature, and social practice.

However, certain thinkers and texts capture the core intuitions of each tradition with particular clarity. The following list highlights some of the most influential sources through which these civilisational responses to the instability of happiness have been articulated.

The purpose is not to provide an exhaustive bibliography but to point toward **representative voices** that illuminate each worldview.

Mediterranean / Aristotelian

Key Thinkers

- Aristotle
- Plato
- Cicero

Key Texts

- *Nicomachean Ethics* — Aristotle
- *Politics* — Aristotle
- *The Republic* — Plato
- *On Duties* (*De Officiis*) — Cicero

Core Idea

Human flourishing arises through the cultivation of virtue and excellence within a well-ordered community.

Indian (Buddhist and Hindu Traditions)

Key Thinkers

- Siddhartha Gautama (the Buddha)
- Vyasa (traditionally associated with the *Bhagavad Gita*)
- Nagarjuna

Key Texts

- *The Dhammapada*
- *The Bhagavad Gita*
- *The Upanishads*
- *Mulamadhyamakakarika* — Nagarjuna

Core Idea

Suffering arises from attachment and craving; liberation comes through insight, disciplined action, and detachment from outcomes.

Northern European / Nietzschean

Key Thinkers

- Friedrich Nietzsche
- Søren Kierkegaard
- Martin Heidegger

Key Texts

- *Thus Spoke Zarathustra* — Nietzsche
- *Beyond Good and Evil* — Nietzsche
- *The Sickness Unto Death* — Kierkegaard
- *Being and Time* — Heidegger

Core Idea

In a world where traditional structures of meaning weaken, individuals must confront existential freedom and create meaning through their actions.

Russian / Dostoevskian

Key Thinkers

- Fyodor Dostoevsky
- Leo Tolstoy
- Nikolai Berdyaev

Key Texts

- *The Brothers Karamazov* — Dostoevsky
- *Crime and Punishment* — Dostoevsky
- *War and Peace* — Tolstoy
- *The Destiny of Man* — Berdyaev

Core Idea

Human suffering, when confronted honestly, can reveal moral and spiritual depth.

East Asian / Confucian

Key Thinkers

- Confucius
- Mencius
- Xunzi

Key Texts

- *The Analects* — Confucius
- *Mencius*
- *The Great Learning*
- *The Doctrine of the Mean*

Core Idea

Meaning emerges through the harmonious fulfillment of social roles within a stable moral order.

Jewish

Key Thinkers

- Moses (as the central figure of the Torah tradition)
- Maimonides
- Martin Buber

Key Texts

- *The Torah* (Hebrew Bible)
- *Guide for the Perplexed* — Maimonides
- *I and Thou* — Martin Buber

Core Idea

Human life is structured through covenant, ethical responsibility, and the ongoing effort to repair the world.

Islamic

Key Thinkers

- The Prophet Muhammad

- Al-Ghazali
- Ibn Sina (Avicenna)
- Ibn Khaldun

Key Texts

- *The Qur'an*
- *The Revival of the Religious Sciences* — Al-Ghazali
- *The Book of Healing* — Ibn Sina
- *The Muqaddimah* — Ibn Khaldun

Core Idea

Human life gains meaning through submission to divine will and alignment with a transcendent moral order.

Polynesian

Unlike many philosophical traditions, Polynesian worldviews were primarily transmitted through **oral tradition** rather than formal philosophical texts.

Key Sources

- Creation chants and genealogical traditions
- Navigational knowledge systems
- Oral histories and mythological cycles

Representative Themes

- the sacred relationship between land, sea, and ancestors
- communal identity and kinship
- ecological balance

Core Idea

Human identity is embedded within a living network that includes community, ancestors, and the natural world.

Closing Note

These thinkers and texts represent only entry points into much deeper traditions. Civilisations are not reducible to a handful of books or philosophers.

Yet the works listed above provide windows into the intellectual and spiritual frameworks through which different cultures have confronted the same enduring question:

If happiness is unstable, what should anchor a human life instead?

Across continents and centuries, the answers vary dramatically. Taken together, they reveal the remarkable range of human thought devoted to solving that problem.